

GEN. BIPIN RAWAT BELIEVED THAT **TO COUNTER THE TWIN THREAT FROM CHINA AND PAKISTAN, THEATRE COMMANDS** WERE THE BEST OPTION, ALLOWING FOR THE SYNERGY OF LIMITED RESOURCES

conflict, the ADC will have to coordinate with the ground-based northern and western theatre commands, which will also launch their own air missions. With scant resources, says the IAF, such operations are just not practicable.

"His (Gen. Rawat's) move to have theatre commands was driven by passion and emotion, not logic," says a former deputy chief of the IAF. "His mandate was to bring jointness among the services." He believes that when the line of communication and war doctrine of the three services is different, achieving such jointness is not easy.

Within a week of Gen. Chauhan's appointment, Air Chief Marshal V.R. Chaudhary said, "Each service has a doctrine. The doctrinal aspects of the IAF...should not be compromised by this new structure (theatre commands)." He added that creation of an air defence command "may prove counterproductive". He justified his comments by saying that "air defence and offensive air missions are interdependent and, if executed in isolation, will not only be disjointed but also ineffective in execution of joint strategy."

The air force says that the majority of its inventory is of multi-role aircraft, which are not only limited to one purpose. A senior air marshal says that the IAF's fighter jets range from MiG 21 Bisons, Jaguars, Mirages, MiG 29s and Sukhois to the newly inducted Rafale. Except five squadrons of Jaguars (100 jets), which are solely attack aircraft, all can be used in a defence role too. "With the IAF already short of its combat fleet, if we deploy half of our aircraft in air defence and half in attack, we will lose 50 per cent of assets in a defence role. We cannot divide multi-role aircraft in air defence or ground attack. At the most, we can combine the ground element of air defence, like missiles and radars," the air marshal says. Jointness, he believes, comes with joint planning, which has been missing till now.

Some other IAF officers point out that the area covered under China's western theatre command (Tibet and Xinjiang), where People's Liberation Army (PLA) air defence units have formed a combined Air Defence Control System jointly with the PLA-Air Force (PLAAF), is bigger than the area of India. Thus, they argue for a combined India theatre, since they believe our available assets are capable of catering to one theatre.

It's not just the IAF though, there are voices of dissent over theatre commands in army circles too. A serving lieutenant general says that theatrisation "will require massive planning, and execution may have to be undertaken in phases, which may be spread over years". He adds that the concept should be tried out first with a test command, before disturbing the whole framework. There is also a view that India should not be aping a foreign concept like theatrisation, and that what is suitable for the US and China might not work for the Indian armed forces. Lt Gen. Rakesh Sharma, former adjutant-general, says there is a need for revisiting warfighting—how tactics, weapons systems and command and control are integrated—before we look towards making structural changes like theatrisation. "There is a need for joint war doctrine. Then we can move to have joint commands. A separate doctrine for every force does not suit the purpose of future wars," he says.

Former deputy chief of Integrated Defence Staff (Policy Planning and Force Development) Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja believes that the emphasis has to be on improving combat edge, enhancing multi-domain operational capability, optimal utilisation of scarce resources and creation of an authority to "enforce" integrated operational planning and execution. For this, the first, mandatory step should be to formulate a roadmap laying out a vision for integrated military commands—what we desire to achieve through the transformation, likely challenges and ways to overcome these and the final implementation. All this should be related to the budget and timeline.

Lack of clarity on other fundamental issues contributes to the lack of momentum in theatrisation. Many questions remain unanswered and crucial gaps in planning unfilled—overall command and control structure of theatre commands, the degree of autonomy accorded to theatre commanders over service chiefs, how to provide politico-military guidance to geographically separated theatre commanders, unavailability of tri-service integrated communications, paucity of staff with tri-service exposure, and optimal division of inventories of critical platforms. Lt Gen. Ahuja says that putting these building blocks in place, creating models of future integrated HQs and war gaming could help to make a more convincing case that "the time for theatre commands has come".

Some think India needs its own version of the Goldwater Nichols Act of 1986 that reworked the command structure of the US military. "Like in the US and China, India also needs to promulgate a policy document on national security strategy before getting into structural changes like theatre Commands," says Lt Col. (retd) Manoj K. Channan.

From these diverse voices, it is clear that before being put into place, the concept of theatrisation needs considered evaluation and joint planning, taking into confidence all stakeholders. ■